

Subject -Verb Agreement

RULE 1 The subject and verb must agree in number.

The student sings.

The children sing.

The dog chases the cat.

The dogs chase the cat.

RULE 2 Singular subjects joined by and requires a plural verb except when they mean one thing.

John and David **are** reading novels.

My teacher and my friend **are** here.

My teacher and friend **is** here.

Bread and butter **is** good food.

My classmate and best friend **is** coming to dinner. Ham and egg **is** a popular combination.

The manager and owner of the company **is** present in the meeting.

RULE 3 The pronoun you always takes a plural verb.

You **were** invited to come.

You **sing** so well.

RULE 4 If a sentence begins with here and there,
the verb agrees with subject which follows it.

Here **are** the ways on how to preserve meat.

There **is** a huge gap between the rich and the poor.

There **are** new discoveries every minute of the
day.

Here **is** a basket of apples for you.

RULE 5 The pronouns neither and either are singular and require singular verb.

Neither of the two traffic lights **is** working.

Either car **is** available.

RULE 6 If two subjects, one singular and plural are connected by either/or, neither/nor, the verb agrees with the nearer subject.

Neither the players nor the coach **is** joining.

Either the conductor or the singers **are** attending the concert.

Either my father or my brothers **are** going to meet the buyer.

Either my brothers or my father **is** going to meet the

buyer. Neither Megan nor my sisters **were** listening to my story.

RULE 7 Subordinate clauses and prepositional phrases that come between the subject and the verb don't affect agreement.

Jake, accompanied by his sisters, **is** enrolling in MAVC. Daddy, as well as my brothers, **is** enjoying the party.

The colors of the rainbow **are** beautiful.

RULE 8 The indefinite pronouns several, few, both , many are always plural.

Both were asking to be freed.

Several are seeking for justice

Many are called but few are chosen.

Rule 9 The indefinite pronouns **some, most, all, none** are singular or plural **according to the meaning** of the sentence.

Some of the girls **were** absent

Some of the ice cream **is** left.

Some of the beads **are** missing.

Some of the water **is** gone.

Most of the news **is** good.

Most of the flowers **were** yellow.

All of the pie **is** gone.

All of the pies **are** gone.

None of the garbage **was** picked up.

None of the chairs **were** chipped.

RULE 10 When any of the following indefinite pronouns is the subject, the verb is singular: everybody, each, no one, another, anybody, nobody, every, nothing, everything, anyone, either, neither, everyone, somebody, someone.
Everyone **is** required to attend the workshop.

No one **was** absent during the examination.

Everybody **attends** the meeting.

RULE 11 Expressions of time , money, weight, and distance are singular even if the form is

plural.

Two years **is** a long time to wait.

One million dollars **was** given back to the

owner. Two hundred dollars **is** a lot of money.

Three miles **is** too far to walk.

Five years **is** the maximum sentence for that offense.

Ten dollars **is** a high price to pay.

RULE 12 When the amount of money refers to separate units, the verb is plural.

Five centavo coins **were** found.

60,000 peso bills **were** added to the budget.

RULE 13 Nouns plural informs but singular in meaning takes singular verbs.

Mathematics **is** my favourite subject.

The latest news **is** alarming.

Linguistics **is** an interesting subject.

RULE 14 The following words are always plural: **pants**, **trousers**, **pliers**, **scissors**, **tongs**. However, if the word **pair** is used, the verb is singular

The pants **are** torn into two.

The scissors **are** over there.

The pair of scissors **was** placed on the table.

RULE 15 When the word is preceded by a number it takes a plural verb. When it is preceded by the number it takes singular verb.

A number of students **are** waiting outside.

The number of students outside **is** not recorded yet.

The number of people in the court **represents** the vigilant citizenry.

The number of volunteers **grows** each year.

A number of people **grow** tomatoes each summer.

RULE 16 When fractions are used , the verb agrees with the object of the of phrase.

One half of the cake **was** consumed.

One fourth of the employees **were** attending the seminar. Four-fifths of the mangoes **have** been sold.

Two-fourths of the pizza **was** consumed.

One-half of the watermelons **are** rotten.

RULE 17 Name of a country is always regarded as singular.

Philippines **is** a beautiful place to visit.

RULE 18 Adjectives used as nouns are considered plural.

The poor **are** to be helped.

The efficient **are** what this country needs.

RULE 19 Collective nouns may be singular or plural
depending on whether the individual members are acting
individually or collectively.

The committee **is** against the plan.

The committee **are** of different opinion.

The orchestra **is** playing a hit song.

The orchestra **were** asked to give their musical backgrounds.

The team **is** going to UAE to administer a sport seminar.

The family **are** arguing about the upcoming elections.

The audience **are** listening to the speaker of the
seminar.

RULE 20 Title of books, plays, articles, movies are regarded as singular.

“Great Expectations” **is** a must read novel.

The Avengers is one of the most popular superhero movies of all time.

Rule 21 If a sentence begins with it, the verb is always singular.

It **is** the schools which must assume the responsibility. It **is** us who must take care of the environment.

FINAL

RULE

Only the subject
affects the
verb.

ACTIVITY

1. His pants (was, were) torn during the match.
2. Aron, together with his wife, (greet, greets) the guests of the party.
3. The truthful (is, are) always trustworthy.
4. A number of soldiers (was, were) injured during the war.
5. The number of deceased soldiers (is, are) not stored in the record book.

6. Swimming(is, are) my favorite sport.
7. There (was, were) many difficulties regarding the situation.
8. Here (lie, lies) the tomb of Albert Einstein.
9. Either she or her friends (is, are) responsible for this accident.
10. George and Tamara(doesn't, don't) want to see that movie.

11. Annie and her brothers (is, are) at school.
12. The man with all the birds (live, lives) on my street.
13. Either answer (is, are) acceptable.
14. Nobody (know, knows) the trouble I've seen.
15. Eight dollars (is, are) the price of a movie these days.

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16. The committee members (leads, lead) very different lives in private.
 17. All of the CDs, even the scratched one, (is, are) in this case.
 18. Not only the school but also the library (was, were) shut down for the celebration.
 19. Ten kilometers to school and back (make, makes) for a very long day.
 20. Several (is, are) dropping the class.

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21. To sleep before a test (is, are) an important thing to do.
22. To rest and to take your medicine (is, are) what you need to do now.
23. Harry Potter and the Curse Child (is, are) the latest from J. K. Rowling's.
24. Some of our luggage (was, were) lost.
25. There (is,are) surprisingly few children in our neighbourhood

26. Statistics (i^vs, are) among the most difficult courses in our program.
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27. The class (is, are) debating amongst themselves.
28. The chances of your being promoted (is/are) excellent.
29. Many hours at the driving range (has/have) led us to design golf balls with GPS locators in them.
30. Discovered in the soil of our city garden (was/were) a button dating from the Civil War dating from the turn of the century.